

BACKGROUND HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL

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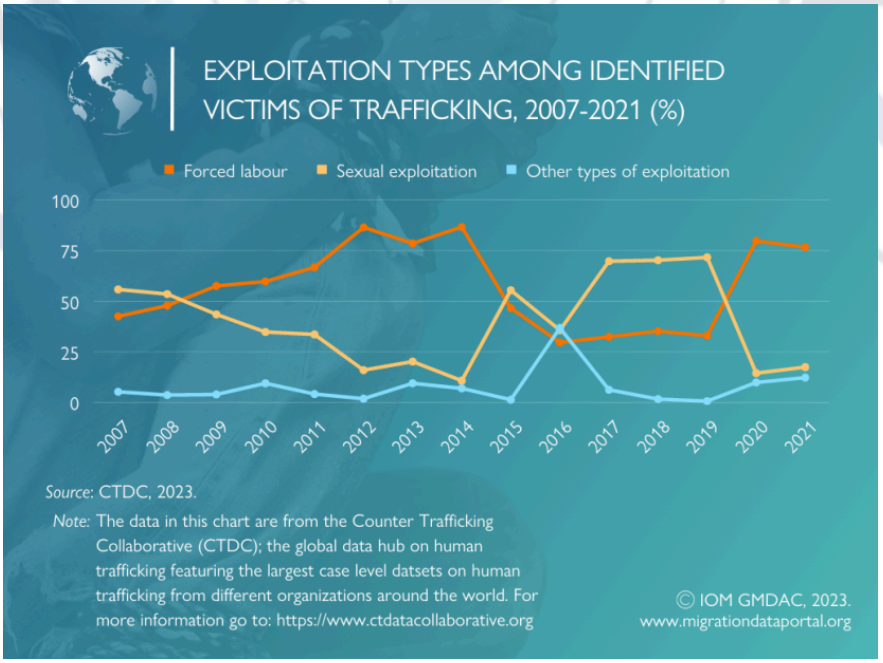
Introduction

"Combating the Global Crisis of Contemporary Slavery: Human Trafficking"

Welcome delegates to the Human Rights Council (HRC) in the 16th edition of the Model of the United Nations Instituto Oriente 2026.On behalf of Instituto Oriente, the Academy of English and the Secretariat, we, as a Chair, are glad to have you and cherish your decision to take part on this committee. This year, the Human Rights Council will discuss a problem that seriously violates the human rights of millions of people worldwide.

This committee is honored to address this topic because slavery, in its historical and modern forms, along with human trafficking, are serious crimes and clearly prohibited under international human rights law. However, despite these legal protections, millions of people around the world continue to suffer forced labor, servitude, and other contemporary forms of slavery.

Human trafficking remains widespread, with countless people exploited for purposes such as sexual and labor abuse, organ removal, forced marriage and coerced criminal activity.



Victims of these abuses often suffer serious human rights violations. Although international law ensures them the right to an effective remedy, many are unable to bring cases to justice. This is often due to a lack of awareness of their rights and numerous systemic obstacles,

including inadequacies in the institutions that are supposed to protect and support them.

The United Nations encourages countries and international organizations to take coordinated action against slavery and human trafficking. It promotes stronger laws, better victim protection, and prosecution of traffickers. Through organs like the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) and HRC, the United Nations (UN) supports cooperation, offers technical help, and raises awareness to prevent these crimes and support victims.

Human Trafficking and Modern Slavery represent grave violations of human rights and are global issues affecting millions of people. These crimes involve the exploitation of individuals through force, fraud, or coercion for the purposes of forced labor, sexual exploitation, domestic servitude, and other forms of modern slavery.

Victims are often among the most vulnerable populations, including women, children, migrants, and those facing economic hardship or social marginalization.

The United Nations plays an important role in the fight against slavery and human trafficking across the globe. Supported by agencies such as the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) and the HRC, the United Nations works with countries to strengthen laws that protect human rights, to prosecute human and organ traffickers, and to provide assistance directly to those affected.

The United Nations also fosters international cooperation to build national capacities for victim detection, law implementation and support systems. In addition, it promotes awareness campaigns, supports research and provides assistance to governments to create global strategies to address the root causes of trafficking, such as poverty, corruption, inequality and lack of education.

The following background contains a historical overview of the committee, a long- and short-term study of the topic, the role of the United Nations, controversial aspects, general objectives for debate, and recommended sources for further research.

The Chair hopes that this document will encourage delegates to engage in reflective debates and propose solutions that defend the dignity and human rights of all people.

History of the Committee

Creation and Background

The Human Rights Council (HRC) was established in 2006, replacing the former Commission on Human Rights, which had existed since 1946. The Commission was established to develop an international legal framework for the protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms in the aftermath of World War II. However, over time, the Commission faced increasing public criticism due to its lack of credibility, politicization and ineffectiveness in addressing serious human rights violations, particularly those committed by influential member states. As a consequence, the United Nations reformed the system and created the HRC, with the objective of securing a more objective, transparent and accountable body capable of protecting and promoting human rights around the world.

Mandate and Objectives

The HRC is the main body responsible for promoting and protecting human rights within the United Nations System. It reviews the human rights performance of all countries and can make specific recommendations on general human rights issues such as reproductive liberties for young people, or on specific situations in particular countries or regions. In doing so, the Council supports the United Nations in maintaining the United Nations mission to promote dignity, equality, and justice for all.

Structure and Membership

Forty-seven countries are elected to participate in the HRC for a three-year term, which may be renewed once consecutively. Membership is elected by the United Nations General Assembly by secret majority vote. The HRC meets for ten weeks a year, divided into three ordinary sessions in March, June and September, and serves as an international discussion forum in Geneva, Switzerland, where human rights issues are debated, often leading to the adoption of resolutions.

Working Mechanisms

- Universal Periodic Review

The Universal Periodic Review (UPR) is a unique mechanism of the Human Rights Council that calls for each UN Member State to undergo a peer review of its human rights records every 4.5 years. Established in

March 2006 by the United Nations General Assembly to encourage, support and expand the promotion and protection of human rights in all countries of the world.

- Special Rapporteurs

The special procedures of the HRC are independent human rights experts with mandates to report and advise on human rights from a thematic or country-specific perspective.

- Special sessions

These are extraordinary meetings convened outside the three regular sessions of the year, when there is an urgent human rights crisis in the world.

Relevant Topics Addressed

The HRC encompasses a wide range of important human rights concerns. According to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR), some of the main issues are civic space and democracy, equality and non-discrimination, justice and the rule of law, peace and security, and development and dignity.

Beyond these thematic areas, the Council has discussed specific issues like migrant rights, human trafficking, children's protection, gender violence, and even climate related concerns.

Relevance in the Current Global Context

By these efforts, the HRC continues to play a crucial role in addressing worldwide challenges and advancing the protection of international human rights. Its capacity to adapt to new forms of human rights violations, such as modern slavery and human trafficking, shows why it remains key in bringing countries together to discuss and respond to global human rights challenges.


The Counter Trafficking Data Collaborative
Data-driven Solutions Against Trafficking and Exploitation
206,549
Individual cases
194
Countries of exploitation
190
Nationalities
About the project
CTDC Global Synthetic Data on Trafficked Persons
Protecting ~206K actual trafficked persons assisted by CTDC partners from 2002 to 2022. Ctrl-click to select multiple attributes.
Guide
238.6K
No. of synthetic records
100%
Data comparability
About synthetic data
Year Of Registration
Chart
List
Select dimension:
Total
Total
30K
20K
10K
0K
Count
2005
2010
2015
2020
Year
Citizenship
Map
List
Highest count
Lowest count
No data
Gender
Count
% of total
Woman 141.1K 74%
Man 48.8K 26%
Trans/Transgender/NonConf... 707 <1%
Age Broad
Count
% of total
0-8 5.7K 5%
09-17 23.9K 19%
18-20 14.6K 12%
21-23 14.6K 12%
24-26 13.6K 11%
27-29 11.4K 9%
30-38 23.5K 19%
39-47 11.1K 9%
48+ 7.0K 6%
Majority status
Count
% of total
Adult 95.8K 76%
Child 29.5K 24%
Trafficking Duration
Count
% of total
0-12 (0-1 yr) 9.7K 44%
13-24 (1-2 yrs) 5.7K 26%
25+ (2+ yrs) 6.7K 30%
Type & Recruit
Means
Sector
Type Of Trafficking
Count
% of total
Sexual Exploit 93.3K 61%
Forced Labour 57.2K 37%
Other Exploit 10.9K 7%
Recruiter Relation
Count
% of total
Other 37.6K 61%
Family 9.9K 16%
Intimate Partner 8.2K 13%
Friend 7.1K 11%
Country Of Exploitation
Map
List
Highest count
Lowest count
No data

Long Term

Historical Background and Origins

Although slavery was officially banned in most countries during the 19th and 20th centuries, the phenomenon never completely disappeared. Instead, it evolved into less visible but equally harmful forms, such as forced labor, sexual exploitation and organ trafficking. In 2000, the United Nations adopted the Palermo Protocol, a key moment in the international fight against human trafficking. This protocol defined the crime and spurred countries to prevent trafficking, protect victims and prosecute perpetrators. However, even with these advances, the problem has continued, especially in areas affected by poverty, conflict and weak legal systems.

In the early 2000, reports from organizations such as the International Labor Organization (ILO) and the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) revealed an increase in trafficking cases. This showed that legal instruments alone were not enough to stop traffickers. Countries needed stronger law enforcement, international cooperation and better support for victims.

Evolution of the Crisis

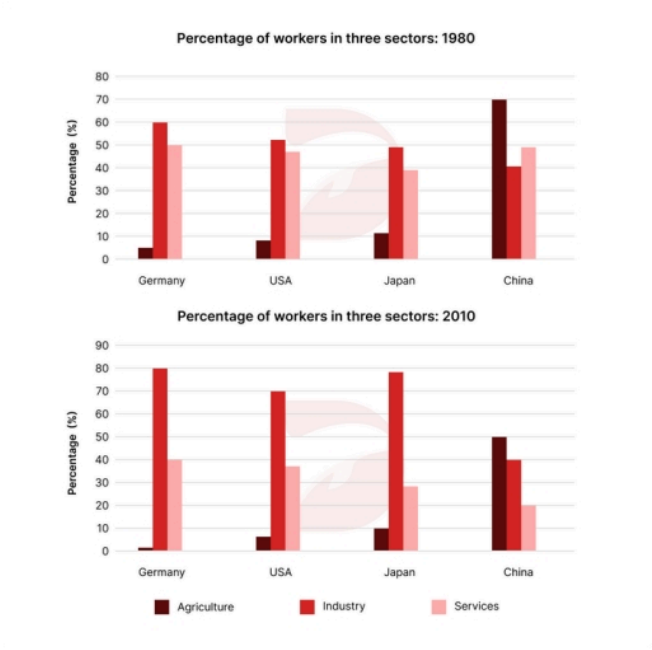
In the last 20 years, human trafficking has become more and more sophisticated. Traffickers have adapted to globalization, migration trends and digital technology. While older forms remain, newer tactics include online recruitment, fake job offers, and the use of social media to manipulate victims. The pandemic of COVID-19 aggravated this situation, forcing more trafficking activity into digital spaces, where it is more difficult to detect.

Criminal Networks are now operating across national borders. Victims are often moved from the developing to the developed regions and exploited for labor, sexual intercourse or even for the organ trade. Conflict zones and humanitarian crises have also been exploited by traffickers in recent years.

Consequences of Human Trafficking

Victims suffer PTSD, anxiety and emotional damage. Many lose access to education, healthcare or basic rights. Integrating them back into society is complex, and survivors are often blamed or treated as criminals. Women, children, immigrants and indigenous populations are the most vulnerable.

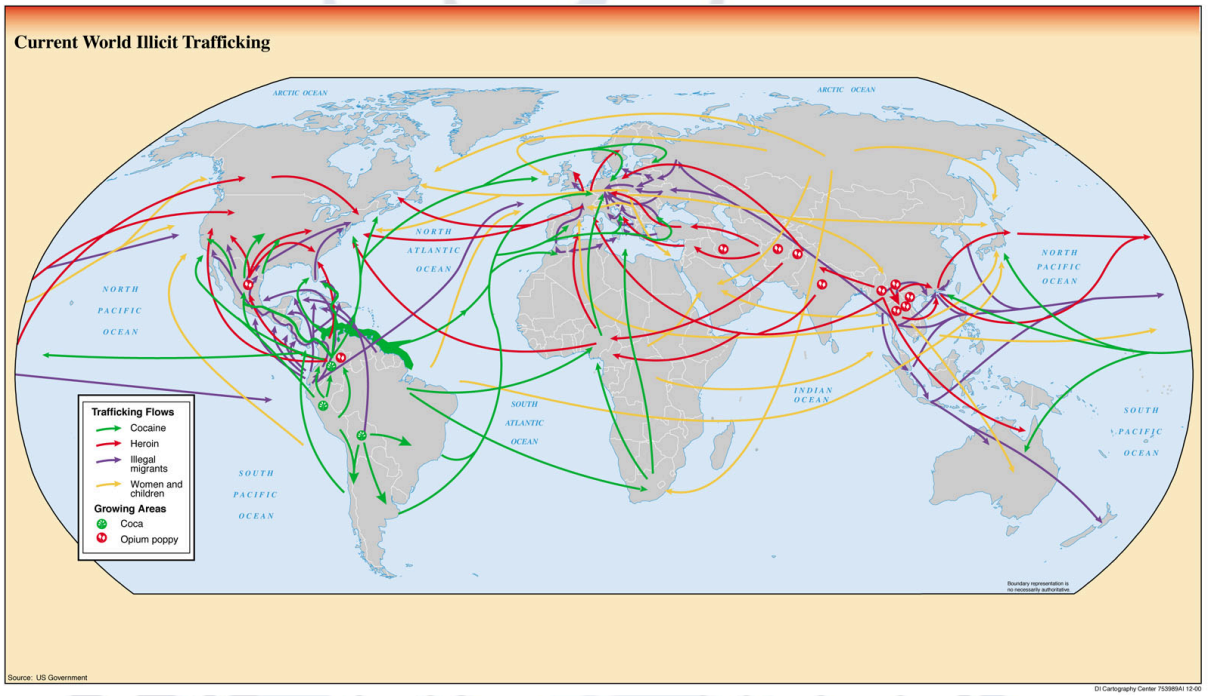
Economically, human trafficking generates more than $150 billion annually for criminal groups.



The victims are forced to work in informal sectors such as agriculture, construction, domestic work and even in modern supply industries. This reduces salaries, increases inequality and weakens economies. Affected countries can suffer reputational damage and reduced foreign investment, especially when they are linked to forced labor.

Human trafficking is a long-standing and constantly evolving global issue. Over the past two decades, it has remained a critical challenge, despite global efforts to combat it. Its social and economic impact is still harming millions of people around the world, especially the most vulnerables.

It is essential for any delegate who is serious about addressing this crime to understand its long-term effects and historical roots. Combating human trafficking calls for long-term strategies that address issues of poverty, inequality, corruption, migration and education. Only by acknowledging its deep roots, everyone can start to dismantle the networks that allow this crime to persist.



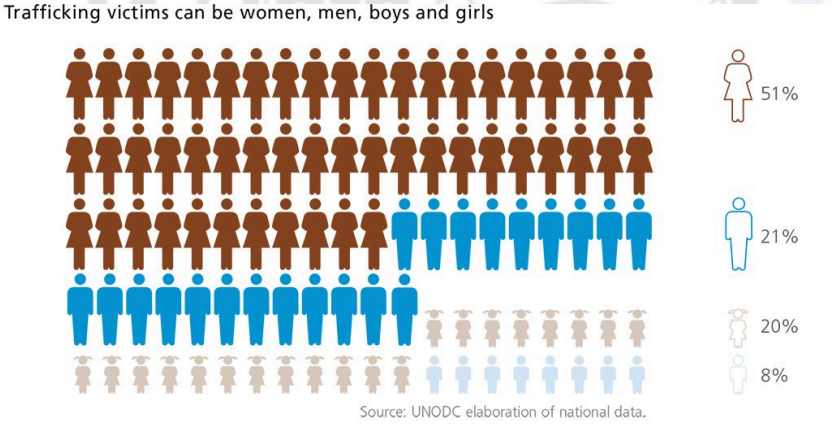
Short Term

Introduction

In recent years, human trafficking has remained a serious global problem. According to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) Global Report (2024), trafficking in persons continues to be reported in every region of the world and affects all types of communities.

Social consequences

In 2022, 69,029 victims of trafficking in persons were detected and reported by 141 countries and territories. Women made up 40 %, men 29 %, girls 22 % and boys 9 %.



Children continue to account for a significant share of victims detected worldwide. The victims are trafficked for multiple types of exploitation, most commonly sexual exploitation and forced labour.

During the pandemic, fewer victims were detected as law enforcement capacity declined, border controls were tightened, and victims had fewer opportunities to report exploitation. Exploitation moved to more hidden forms and spaces, making it harder to identify.

The report adds that the internet, particularly social media platforms and messaging applications, is widely used to recruit victims, especially children. This creates a situation where victims are approached from anywhere, often without realizing the danger until it is too late.

Recruitment happens through fake jobs, romantic offers or promises of a better life.

Economic consequences

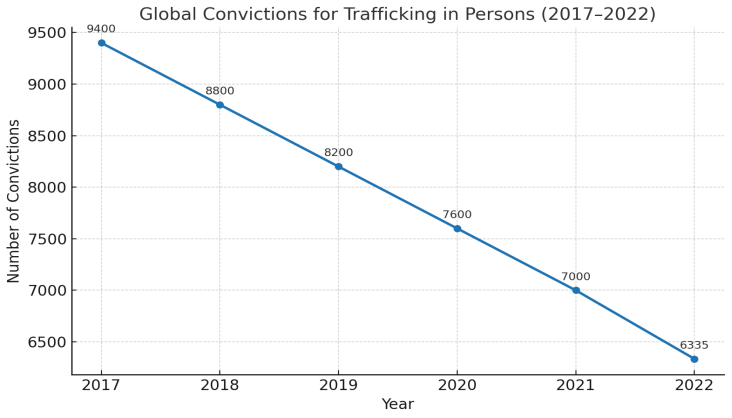
According to the report, new types of trafficking have emerged, such as forced labour for online scams. In these cases, victims are forced to operate fraudulent investment schemes, love scams or extortion via the internet. These activities are often run from large compounds in Southeast Asia, where thousands of people are held against their will.

Trafficking is now part of a broader illegal digital economy. Offenders increasingly use encrypted communication channels and virtual currencies to operate anonymously and transfer illicit profits. The shift toward digital platforms allows for faster movement of money and makes investigations harder.

The pandemic also worsened economic conditions globally. The UNODC states that people in vulnerable situations, especially migrants and job seekers, are more likely to accept risky offers that lead to trafficking.

Political and legal consequences

In terms of legal action, 6,335 trafficking offenders were convicted across 97 countries in 2022. However, this is a notable decrease from previous years. For comparison, the number of convictions was over 9,400 in 2017.



This shows that many countries still face challenges in prosecuting traffickers.

The report highlights that some countries have introduced innovative legal frameworks to better address trafficking, including non-punishment of victims and stronger protection systems. These efforts help prevent re-victimization and improve institutional responses.

Still, criminal networks continue to evolve faster than national and international legal systems. The use of digital tools makes enforcement more complex, and the international nature of trafficking demands cooperation between countries, which remains limited in many cases.

Topic and the United Nations

International Legal Frameworks

Human trafficking represents one of the most severe and widespread human rights violations of this century. The United Nations has established firm foundations to combat this crime through legal instruments such as the Protocol to Prevent, Suppress and Punish Trafficking in Persons, Especially Women and Children, adopted in 2000 under the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime. Known as the Palermo Protocol, this document, ratified by over 170 countries, defines trafficking in persons and obliges States to prevent it, protect victims, and prosecute offenders.

Operational Efforts and Key UN Agencies

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) and the Human Rights Council (HRC) lead operational and monitoring efforts. They assist in the creation of national strategies, offer technical support, and coordinate fieldwork. The Global Plan of Action to Combat Trafficking in Persons, adopted in 2010, reinforces international cooperation, the development of legal structures, and the protection of those affected. It also calls attention to the need to address underlying causes such as inequality, lack of educational opportunities, and corruption.



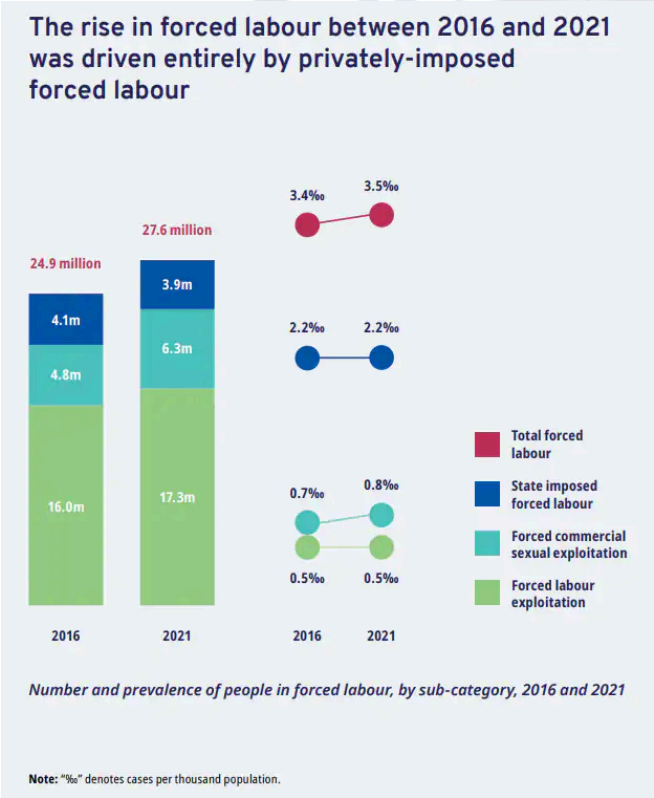
Connection with the 2030 Agenda

The issue of human trafficking is directly addressed in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. Specific targets such as Goal 5.2 aim to eliminate all forms of violence against women and girls, Goal 8.7 seeks to eradicate forced labor and modern slavery, and Goal 16.2 focuses on ending child exploitation and abuse.

These objectives reflect the deep interconnection between development, human rights, and anti-trafficking efforts.

Statistics and Global Reality

Despite progress, enforcement remains inconsistent. According to data from the International Labour Organization and the Walk Free Foundation, an estimated 50 million people are currently trapped in modern slavery, with 27.6 million in forced labor. Women and girls represent 71% of the total victims, and one-third are children.



These alarming statistics demonstrate that trafficking thrives in environments marked by social and economic instability.

Capacity Building and Victim Support

To face these challenges, the United Nations promotes training programs for border control, judicial procedures, and labor inspections. It supports the UN Voluntary Trust Fund for Victims of Trafficking in Persons, which provides essential services such as legal aid, medical care, and psychological support. At the same time, initiatives like the Blue Heart Campaign are key in raising awareness

and mobilizing global actors, including the private sector, to prevent and respond to trafficking effectively.

A Coordinated and Human-Centered Approach

Ultimately, the UN emphasizes that human trafficking is not only a crime but a multidimensional issue rooted in global inequalities. Through a coordinated strategy focused on prevention, protection, and capacity-building, the United Nations encourages States to address the systemic conditions that allow trafficking to persist. The goal is not only to pursue justice but to uphold the principles of dignity, equality, and respect for all individuals.

Human Rights-Based Approach and Special Focus on Vulnerable Groups

The UN emphasizes that any response to trafficking must follow a human rights-based approach, ensuring that victims are not treated as criminals. Special attention is given to women and girls, unaccompanied minors, refugees, and migrant workers, groups who are disproportionately affected by trafficking-related crimes.

The Committee on the Elimination of Discrimination against Women (CEDAW) and the Committee on the Rights of the Child (CRC) are essential in monitoring how countries comply with international standards, especially regarding forced sexual intercourse, child exploitation, and trafficking for forced marriage.

Use of Digital Technologies and Data Sharing Initiatives

The United Nations acknowledges that technology plays a dual role in human trafficking. While digital platforms are often used by criminal groups to recruit and exploit victims, they can also be used for good. The UNODC supports the use of artificial intelligence, blockchain, and big data to trace trafficking patterns, monitor supply chains, and identify victims.

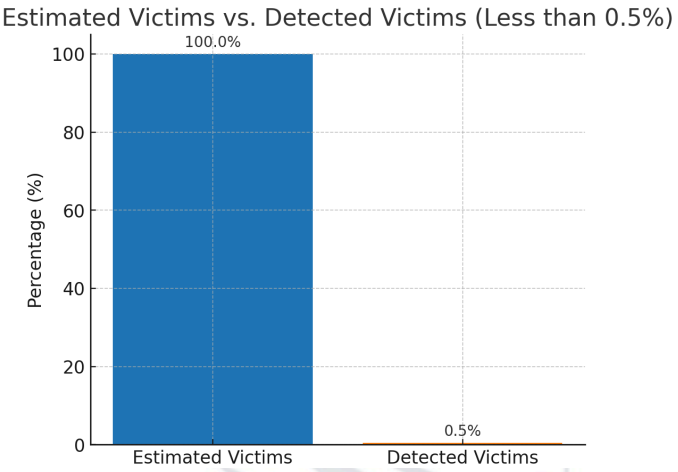
Through initiatives such as GRIDS (Global Response against Trafficking in Supply Chains) and the Data Collaboration Platform, the UN encourages countries and companies to increase transparency, share intelligence, and track exploitation risks in real time.

Controversy Points

The Executive Director of the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) noted that perhaps we, as a society, simply prefer to close our eyes to it, as many law-abiding citizens buy the products and the services produced on the cheap by slaves. This illustrates the contrast between legal condemnation and practical inaction, highlighting a central point of contention.

Why is the topic controversial?

The controversial nature of human trafficking arises in part from the disparity between the scale of the problem and the effectiveness of governmental responses. This amounts to less than 0.5% of estimated victims being recognized by authorities.



The enormous gap between the legal framework and the actual enforcement exposes systemic weaknesses and triggers criticism of how governments handle the issue.

Positions on Human Trafficking

There are divergent approaches to how human trafficking should be addressed. International bodies and non-governmental organizations (NGOs) advocate for stronger protection mechanisms and victim centred strategies, including access to services and legal aid. However, state responses often place emphasis on immigration control rather

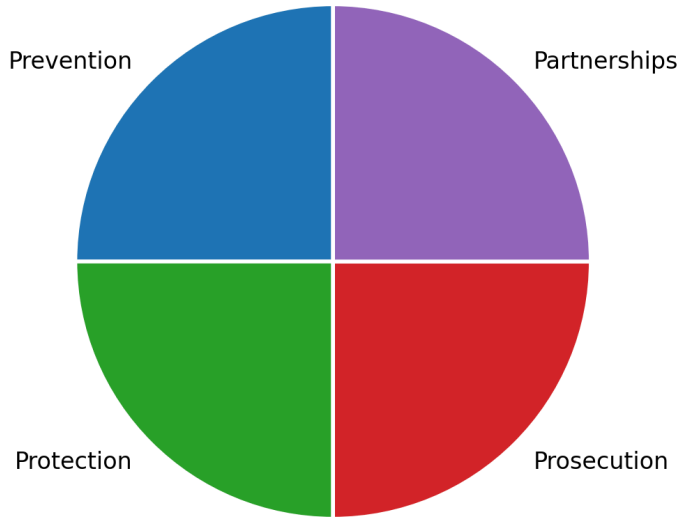
than recognising trafficking as a human rights violation. The Anti Trafficking Monitoring Group (ATMG), for example, criticised the United Kingdom's National Referral Mechanism (NRM) for focusing on immigration status rather than on the crime itself. Similarly, End Child Prostitution, Child Pornography and Trafficking of Children for Sexual Purposes in the United Kingdom (ECPAT UK) has documented cases where trafficked children involved in cannabis cultivation have been prosecuted rather than protected.

The debate is further fuelled by inconsistencies in victim identification, gaps in data collection, and differences in national priorities. Reports have highlighted the need for better training of public officials, greater cooperation between agencies, and clearer distinctions between trafficking and related crimes such as smuggling. These challenges, combined with conflicting institutional approaches and limited political will, contribute to the continuing controversy over how states define, detect, and respond to human trafficking.

Objectives

This committee aims to promote comprehensive and coordinated national responses to human trafficking, in line with the approach supported by the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) through its Global Action Against Trafficking in Persons and the Smuggling of Migrants (GLO.ACT) initiative. The objective is to strengthen legislative, policy, and institutional frameworks by addressing the crime through four core pillars: prevention, protection, prosecution, and partnerships.

Four Core Pillars against Human Trafficking



In doing so, the committee encourages a victim-centered and trauma-informed perspective, particularly focusing on vulnerable populations, including children and youth, as highlighted by national and international advisory bodies. It also aims to emphasize the importance of improving data collection, referral mechanisms, and legal tools to assist victims and hold perpetrators accountable.

Through structured dialogue and international cooperation, this committee seeks to guide the development of a resolution that reflects

global standards, reinforces national capacities, and promotes sustained action against trafficking in persons across all regions.

To ensure effective and sustainable responses, the committee emphasizes the need for capacity building in legal systems, increased inter-agency coordination, and stronger cross-border cooperation. These efforts must align with international standards while respecting national contexts.

The Human Rights Council also recognizes the importance of accurate data collection, victim identification protocols, and accessible services for survivors. Promoting survivor inclusion in policy development is key to ensuring lasting impact and relevance.

Delegates are encouraged to keep in mind the long-term nature of anti-trafficking efforts and the importance of multisectoral engagement, including the role of civil society, non-governmental organizations, and regional networks.

This committee will work toward a resolution that not only addresses the immediate dimensions of trafficking in persons but also reinforces the political and institutional commitment needed to combat it globally.

Conclusion

Throughout this paper, key aspects of modern slavery and human trafficking have been explored, from their root causes to their devastating social, political and economic consequences. Statistics show that millions of people, especially women, children and people with lack of resources, remain trapped in exploitative circumstances that violate their dignity and human rights.

It is essential to recognize that human trafficking is not just a legal or criminal matter of concern, but a profound humanitarian crisis. Greater commitment to prevention, support for survivors and international cooperation is needed urgently. Addressing these challenges requires a multidimensional and inclusive approach that is grounded in human rights principles, protects vulnerable populations and strengthens global solidarity.

This Committee encourages participants to reflect on the urgency of this issue and the importance of promoting solutions that are ethical, viable and sustainable. Delegates are expected to address the debate with empathy, critical thinking and a desire to shape concrete proposals that can be translated into real impact.

The Human Rights Council hopes that this background paper provides a solid basis for debate. The goal is to promote significant participation, thoughtful negotiation and innovative proposals that will help in the global fight against trafficking and modern slavery.

Thank you for choosing this committee. Your engagement, responsibility and awareness are vital to the success of this experience and to the mission of the United Nations.



"The best way to find yourself is to lose yourself in the service of others."

— Mahatma Gandhi

Countries

Federal Republic of Germany

Germany serves as a source, transit, and destination country for men, women, and children subjected to forced labor and sexual exploitation. According to available data, most convicted offenders receive little to no prison time, raising concerns that penalties may not deter traffickers. Identified victims have included individuals from within Europe especially Germany, Romania, and Bulgaria as well as from outside Europe, including Nigeria and parts of Asia and the Americas. Common settings for forced labor include hotels, restaurants, construction sites, and domestic work. Authorities have made some progress in prosecuting both sex and labor trafficking cases.

Federal Republic of Nigeria

Nigeria functions as a source, transit, and destination country for women and children subjected to forced labor and sex trafficking. In 2023, the government initiated 698 trafficking investigations, including 333 sex trafficking cases, 172 labor trafficking cases, and 193 unspecified cases.

People's Republic of China

China is a source, transit, and destination country for men, women, and children subjected to forced labor and sex trafficking. Victims are exploited in industries such as mining, construction, and brick kilns. Forced marriages continue to occur, especially in regions with gender imbalances. Although the government has taken some steps, like raising awareness about scams in Southeast Asia, serious concerns remain about widespread exploitation and lack of victim protection.

Republic of India

India is a source, transit, and destination country for men, women, and children subjected to forced labor and sex trafficking. Victims are often exploited in sectors like agriculture, construction, domestic work, and manufacturing. Despite having laws like the Bonded Labour System (Abolition) Act and the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act, enforcement

remains limited. In 2023, the government investigated 201 trafficking cases and secured convictions in only 32 of them. Many cases are dropped or delayed, and 81% of trafficking cases end in acquittal, showing challenges in the justice system. Internal trafficking is especially common, with vulnerable communities such as lower castes, tribal groups, and poor women and children being the most affected.

United States of America

The United States of America understands trafficking in persons as a crime including forced labor and commercial sex acts executed through force, fraud, or coercion. The Office to Monitor and Combat Trafficking in Persons, part of the U.S. Department of State, publishes the annual Trafficking in Persons (TIP) Report. These instruments underpin the country's leadership in combating trafficking globally. The Trafficking Victims Protection Act of 2000 reauthorized several times provides legal protections for victims and strengthens legal action against perpetrators.

Countries in G5 :

1. French Republic
2. People's Republic of China
3. Russian Federation
4. United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
5. United States of America

Members of the organization:

6. Islamic Republic of Pakistan
7 . People's Republic of Bangladesh
8. Republic of Honduras
9. Republic of India
10. Socialist Republic of Vietnam

Countries invited to the debate:

11. Arab Republic of Egypt
12. Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela
13. Canada
14. Commonwealth of Australia
15. Democratic People's Republic of Korea
16. Democratic Republic of the Congo
17. Federal Republic of Germany
18. Federative Republic of Brazil
19. Islamic Republic of Afghanistan
20. Kingdom of Norway
21. Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
22. Kingdom of Spain
23. Kingdom of Sweden
24. Republic of Indonesia
25. Republic of South Africa
26. Republic of the Sudan
27. Republic of Türkiye
28. Republic of Yemen
29. State of Qatar
30. Swiss Confederation
31. Syrian Arab Republic
32. United Arab Emirates
33. United Mexican States
34. Ukraine

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"Those who believe in the world are the ones meant to change it."

President: Agustín Sánchez Peláez
Moderator: Elena Dionne Murillo
Secretary: Natalia García Rubio

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